home, until his death at the age of sixty-two, he worked in Xian with a team of linguist monks to translate many of the 657 books that survived his journey (a few were lost while crossing the Indus) into Chinese and wrote commentaries on them. He also published an extensive account of his travels,[14] which is now an invaluable historical and archaeological record.

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Yijing likely witnessed Xuanzang's grand funeral in Chang'an. He was then a young Buddhist monk. Inspired by 'the noble enthusiasm of Xuanzang', Yijing longed to follow in his footsteps to India. At thirty, Yijing became serious about his dream, found a sponsor for his journey and set sail on a Persian boat for the kingdom of Srivijaya in Sumatra, where he stayed for many months with other foreign scholars and learnt Sanskrit. In the preceding centuries, Indian merchants had not only brought Buddhism to South East Asia but also a linguistic script, religious texts and rituals, literature, art, architecture and countless other aspects of Indian culture, immersion in which helped Yijing prepare for India.

He arrived by sea in 673 CE at a place called Tamralipti, near modern Kolkata. There, at a monastery, he met a Mahayana teacher and stayed with him for a year, learning Sanskrit. He then travelled by foot to Nalanda with his teacher, 'twenty fellow priests of Nalanda' and 'hundred merchants', finding strength in numbers through a 'dangerous and perilous road', across 'a big mountain and bogs'.[15] En route, he was struck 'by an illness of the season' and grew 'very weak and tired'. He couldn't keep up with the group and fell behind. Finding him alone, some mountain brigands descended on him, stripped him naked and took all his belongings. He had heard the rumour that in these parts they liked sacrificing light-skinned people. Though despairing and fearful, he managed to escape. He writes, 'I entered into a muddy hole, and besmeared all my body with mud. I covered myself with leaves, and supporting myself on a stick, I advanced slowly', until he was united with his worried teacher 'calling out for him from outside the village'.

A few days later Yijing reached Nalanda, where he stayed for ten years. He also travelled in the Gangetic Plain to the places associated with the